

Focus Group Discussion Guide

The Blueprint We Arrive With: how attachment style shapes fear of rejection and friendship formation among BRAC University undergraduates.

Group 02 · Section 11 **60 min** **6-8 participants**, mixed styles Moderator + note-taker
Recorded with written consent

HOW TO RUN THE ROOM

A question has worked when two participants start answering *each other* and you have gone quiet. Each card gives you the line to read aloud, the probes to push with, and what that question pulls for the transcript.

- Read the line, then **wait seven seconds**. Never answer your own question or give your own example — the first example anchors everything after it.
- One person dominating: *"That's one version. Who does it completely differently?"* Someone answering you instead of the group: *"Say that to him, not to me."*
- Never say **secure, anxious, avoidant, attachment** or **disorganized** in the room. A labelled participant performs the label.
- Bring quiet ones in with low-cost entries — a hand, a number on fingers, one word. Never *"and what about you?"*
- Hand and finger counts are data: the note-taker writes them down **as they happen**. Also log who agreed with whom, who switched position, and any quotable first-person sentence.

WHAT THE TAGS MEAN

ANXIETY

Hyperactivation — reassurance-seeking, reading meaning into silence, fear of being left.

AVOIDANCE

Deactivation — self-reliance as identity, need framed as weakness.

LONELINESS

Lacking companionship, feeling left out or isolated — including inside a group.

NERVOUSNESS

Social anxiety and fear of negative evaluation — the body before the approach.

REJECTION

Rejection sensitivity — what they expect to happen versus what actually happens.

APPROACH-AVOIDANCE

Wanting closeness and blocking it at once — the fearful pattern.

CHILDHOOD BRIDGE

Link-back probe: walk what they just described on campus back to the house they grew up in.

00:00

OPENING 3 min

read

- ▶ Ground rules, read aloud before recording starts.

"One person speaks at a time. Disagreement is welcome — this only works if you argue with each other. Nothing said here leaves the room. First names or nicknames only. You can pass on any question or stop at any point. Nobody is being assessed. May I start recording?"

Confirm on the recording that everyone has signed consent. Remind them names become pseudonyms.

00:03

WARM-UP 7 min

Q1

Round the table: your name, your semester, and if a class got cancelled right now, who at BRACU would you text first — and how did you two actually meet?

- Did you go to them, or did they come to you?
- Seating, group project, club — or did somebody actually decide to start it?
- Anyone who thought about it and didn't have a name?

Pulls: how friendships here begin — accident and proximity vs. deliberate approach — and who moved first. **Tell:** the participant with no name to give is your quiet loneliness case; note them, return gently at Q10.

LONELINESS

note: initiator vs. approached

Q2

One word each — what does walking into a new section in week one feel like? Say your word. Then hands up if someone else's word was closer to it than your own.

- To a raised hand: whose word, and what made it closer?
- Take two opposite words and make those two talk to each other.

Pulls: the room's baseline vocabulary for one identical situation — "exciting" against "exhausting" against "awkward" — for almost no cost to the speaker.

NERVOUSNESS

LONELINESS

record all words verbatim

00:10

THE VIGNETTE 13 min

read

- ▶ Read slowly. Do not comment — go straight to Q3.

"Rafi has been in the same section for five weeks. Every day the same three people sit together near the front, talking and laughing. He has thought about joining them eleven times. Today he opens his phone, types '*hey, mind if I sit here?*', reads it twice — and deletes it."

Q3

What is Rafi hearing in his head while he types that? Don't tell me "he's scared of rejection" — give me the actual sentence, in his words.

- Whose voice is that sentence in?
- Would he say it out loud to a friend, or does it only live in his head?
- Anyone hear a different sentence? Say yours.

Pulls: verbatim self-talk — "they'll think I'm desperate", "they already have their group".

Highest-value quote of the session; get it word for word. **Tell:** how catastrophic the prediction is, and how certain they sound about it.

NERVOUSNESS

REJECTION

verbatim, all versions

Q4

Hands up — who has been Rafi this semester? Keep them up, look around. Now put them down and tell me what you actually did with that feeling.

▸ Count the hands out loud so it lands on the recording.

- How long did you sit with it before giving up on it?
- Did you open that chat again later?
- Anyone here send it instead of deleting it? What happened?

Pulls: the behaviour, not the feeling — deleting, delaying, rehearsing, waiting to be

approached. **Tell:** senders and deleters explain the same situation with completely different logic.

AVOIDANCE

NERVOUSNESS

hands: ____ / ____

Q5

If Rafi had sent it — what happens? I want someone who thinks it goes badly and someone who thinks it goes fine. Argue it out.

▸ If nobody takes the other side, split the room: "This half, you're the optimists. Convince them."

- Optimists: why so sure? Have you tested it?
- Pessimists: has that actually happened to you, or is it what you expect?
- Say the worst realistic outcome out loud. Could you survive that one?

Pulls: the gap between expected and lived rejection — certainty without a real instance is

rejection sensitivity in conversational form. **Tell:** note who revises their position after hearing the other side.

REJECTION

who switched sides

Q6

Rafi didn't learn this last week. When he was small and wanted something from an adult in his house — what do you think usually happened?

CHILDHOOD BRIDGE

"...and does that house sound familiar to anyone here?"

- Told to wait? Ignored? Given it some days and not others?
- Did asking twice make it better or worse in that house?
- Who grew up somewhere close to what you've just described?

Pulls: participants building their own history into Rafi — the safest route into childhood in a group, because they're describing a character, not confessing. Inconsistent responsiveness points anxious; need dismissed points avoidant; unpredictability or fear points fearful. **Tell:** mark whoever says "that's basically my house" — Q8 and Q9 can go back to them directly.

CHILDHOOD BRIDGE

REJECTION

Q7

Same classroom, different person: someone who never even considers joining that table. Fine at the back, headphones on, doesn't want the seat. What's their story — is that strength, or the same fear wearing a different shirt?

- Could you tell those two apart from the outside?
- Would you rather be Rafi or be that person? Why?
- Anyone here who'd describe themselves as that person?

Pulls: whether the room frames self-sufficiency as virtue, defence, or story. **Tell:** whoever defends the back-row person hardest is usually describing themselves — they'll carry Q9.

AVOIDANCE

Q8

A close friend has left your message on seen since yesterday morning, and has been online twice. Hands: who says that means nothing? Who says something is wrong? — Now talk to each other about it, not to me.

▸ 6 min. Let it run; step in only to bring in someone who hasn't spoken.

- "Something's wrong" side: what's the *first* explanation your brain reaches for — not the reasonable one, the first one?
- Do you check their last-seen? Send a second message? Write one and not send it?
- "Means nothing" side: is that true, or what you've trained yourself to say?

CHILDHOOD BRIDGE

"Growing up, when someone at home went quiet on you — did that usually mean something? Did silence in your house mean trouble was coming, or just silence?"

Pulls: hyperactivation — re-reading, checking last-seen, drafting and deleting, needing confirmation that nothing is wrong. **Tell:** participants who read silence as threat very often report a home where silence *was* a warning. Note anyone who makes that link without you suggesting it.

ANXIETY

CHILDHOOD BRIDGE

hands: nothing ____ / wrong ____

Q9

Someone said it earlier without saying it, so let's say it: needing people is weak. Who agrees?

▸ Deliberately provocative. Let them fight — don't correct anyone, don't soften it. Then hand them the concrete version.

Now the real version. Last time you were genuinely struggling — an assignment, money, something at home — how many people knew? Show me on your fingers. Look around. Now tell me why that number and not one more.

- Who would have had to ask before you'd have said anything?
- Anyone you'd never tell? What do you think would happen if you did?
- To a high number: did you tell them, or did they notice?

CHILDHOOD BRIDGE

"In the house you grew up in — what happened when somebody showed they needed help?"

Pulls: deactivation — "I don't want to burden anyone", "there's no point telling people". The finger count is a countable anchor sitting right beside the reasoning that explains it. **Tell:** watch for whoever argues hardest that needing people is fine, then shows one finger.

AVOIDANCE

CHILDHOOD BRIDGE

fingers: one number per person

Q10

There's being alone, and there's being left out — not the same thing. Which one does this campus do to people? And can somebody describe what being left out actually looks like here, on an ordinary Tuesday?

- Can you be lonely *inside* a friend group you're already in? Anyone lived that?
- Anyone been in the group photo and still felt outside it?
- "Everyone already has their group by now." True, or an excuse?

Pulls: loneliness separated from solitude in their own words, with concrete detail — the cafeteria table, the group chat you're in but not in, plans made in front of you. Loneliness *inside* a group separates the anxious and fearful patterns from simple isolation. **Tell:** where they put the blame — campus, timing, or themselves.

LONELINESS

ANXIETY

Q11

Nobody here actually says "no" out loud. So how do you know when you've been rejected? What does it look like on this campus?

- Body check: right before you speak to someone new, what happens physically? Name it. — Who else gets exactly that one?
- Ever decided someone didn't want you around and later found out you were wrong?
- Which costs more: saying hello and getting nothing back, or never saying hello? Pick a side and defend it.

Pulls: what counts as rejection when nothing was said — short replies, plans made without you, left on seen, not tagged. The body check gives clean somatic anxiety data in their own vocabulary, and the hands tell you how shared it is. **Tell:** the last probe is the whole study in one sentence — cost of approaching vs. cost of not.

REJECTION

NERVOUSNESS

hands per symptom named

Q12

Is there someone you wish you were closer to — but you're the one keeping the distance?

► Keep it plain and short. Ask, then wait. If it lands, let it run past its time.

- What would have to change for you to close that gap?
- Is it something about them, or is it you?
- Anyone else have a person like that?

Pulls: wanting closeness and blocking it in the same breath — the fearful pattern, hardest to reach with a scale. **Tell:** real warmth described, followed by a reason for the distance the speaker doesn't sound convinced by.

APPROACH-AVOIDANCE

Q13

One sentence each: something you wish somebody had said to you in your first week here.

- Would you have believed it at the time?

Pulls: what each participant thinks was missing — reassurance, permission, information, or someone approaching first. Ends constructively, which matters after Q9 and Q12.

LONELINESS

NERVOUSNESS

Q14

Last one. Was anything said in this room today that you disagreed with and didn't say at the time? Now's the moment.

- Anything you said earlier that you'd take back?
- Anything you were surprised nobody else said?

Pulls: suppressed dissent — where quieter participants give their real position and the group's dominant narrative gets contradicted. **Tell:** transcribe this carefully; it's your check against the loudest voice having shaped everything.

ANXIETY

AVOIDANCE

LONELINESS

NERVOUSNESS

read

- 00:57 — closing script, then stop the recording.

"Thank you. Nothing said here will be linked to your name, and I'd ask you all to keep what was said in this room. If anything we talked about is sitting heavily with you, here is the contact for the BRAC University Counselling and Wellness Centre — please use it."

Hand the Counselling Centre card to every participant, not only whoever looked affected. Moderator and note-taker debrief within thirty minutes: who spoke least, what surprised you, what to change for the next group.

Every construct is pulled at more than one point, so no conclusion rests on a single question. Childhood is not a section — it enters three times, always *after* the group has described the present-day behaviour, so participants explain a pattern they have just admitted to rather than account for their families cold.

CONSTRUCT	PULLED AT	COUNTABLE DATA
ANXIETY	Q8 · Q10 · Q14	Q8 hand split
AVOIDANCE	Q4 · Q7 · Q9 · Q14	Q4 hands, Q9 finger counts
LONELINESS	Q1 · Q2 · Q10 · Q13 · Q14	Q1 participants with no name to give
NERVOUSNESS	Q2 · Q3 · Q4 · Q11 · Q13 · Q14	Q11 hands per symptom
REJECTION	Q3 · Q5 · Q6 · Q11	Q5 side-switches
APPROACH-AVOIDANCE	Q7 · Q12	—
CHILDHOOD BRIDGE	Q6 · Q8 · Q9	—

Transcripts coded line by line, codes grouped into themes, themes compared across the four screening styles (Braun & Clarke, 2006). Two team members code independently; disagreements resolved by discussion, not averaging. Screening scores describe participants alongside their quotes and are never used to diagnose. Items adapted from Bartholomew & Horowitz (1991), Downey & Feldman (1996), Fraley, Waller & Brennan (2000), Leary (1983), Russell (1996).